

Study 1

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Core Details

Created On:	November 13, 2025
Target Audience:	Students aged 18 to 25 from the Faculty of Mathematics at the Autonomous University of Yucatán who live in Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico.
Research Goal:	Gather opinions about the use of a carpooling application for offering rides as driver between the university and a point near their home, including their openness to receiving only an optional payment or contribution from passengers, and the safety factors that would influence their decision to offer rides through the app.
Study Strategy:	Dynamic Interview
Language:	english

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Executive Summary

Brief description: Concise overview of student attitudes toward offering rides via a university-focused carpooling app, covering safety requirements, optional payments, and controls drivers need to feel comfortable participating.

Key Insights

1. Safety and identity verification are prerequisites for driver participation

- Summary: Drivers require robust verification (university affiliation, photo match, contact confirmation), in-app communication, and emergency features before they will offer rides to unfamiliar passengers.
- Impact: Without trusted verification and safety tooling, many potential drivers will restrict rides to known peers, reducing the app's reach and utility. Strong ID checks, verifiable student status, real-time location sharing during trips, SOS functionality, and bidirectional ratings create accountability and lower perceived risk; together these features increase willingness to pick up strangers, enable later adoption during evening hours, and reduce off-platform coordination that undermines safety.
- Variations: Comfort levels shift by time of day (daytime > nighttime), by prior familiarity (classmate/tutee vs stranger), and by individual risk tolerance. Some users will accept lighter verification if other signals (mutual connections, positive ratings) exist, while others insist on formal institutional checks.

2. Optional payments motivate drivers but must remain non-transactional and flexible

- Summary: Small optional contributions are appreciated to offset fuel and maintenance, but drivers resist turning rides into formal paid services or having mandatory fees/large platform cuts.
- Impact: If payments are optional, transparent, and easy (in-app micro-contributions), they improve driver sustainability and retention without eroding social goodwill. Conversely, mandatory payments, large commission fees, or monetization that changes social dynamics will deter drivers who currently offer favors among classmates. The app should enable optional auto-contributions, suggest fair cost-sharing, and limit platform fees to protect the community-oriented feel while maintaining driver participation.

- Variations: Environmentally motivated users may accept offering more unpaid rides; budget-constrained drivers will lean on contributions. The acceptability of payments also depends on existing relationships—drivers are more comfortable receiving contributions from peers they know than from strangers.

3. Driver control (preferences, selective availability, and clear communication) determines sustained use

- Summary: Drivers want granular controls—who they match with, time windows, route limits, and in-app messaging—so they can preserve autonomy and avoid feeling obligated or overburdened.
- Impact: Platform adoption depends on respecting drivers' boundaries: features like availability toggles, faculty/route filters, maximum detour/time settings, pre-ride messaging, and one-time location sharing reduce friction and psychological pressure. If drivers feel tracked, quota-bound, or constantly solicited, they will opt out or limit offers. Enabling predictable, low-effort interactions protects personal time, prevents exploitation, and sustains the informal reciprocity that currently supports peer rides.
- Variations: More extroverted or altruistic drivers may welcome broader matching and social interactions; introverted or busy drivers will favor conservative filters and minimal-contact modes. Some drivers want preference for same-faculty matches; others prioritize route efficiency over affiliation.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "The option for passengers to make an optional payment or contribution would definitely be a motivating factor for me."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "I need to know this person is actually a UADY student, not just someone who figured out how to game the system."

Key Takeaways

- Prioritize robust verification, emergency features, and fine-grained driver controls to convert cautious drivers into regular app users.
- The most surprising tension: drivers value community and environmental benefits but will abandon participation if the app makes rides feel like paid work, enforces quotas, or weakens their autonomy.

Openness to Carpooling

Brief description: Students show conditional openness to offering rides — generally positive when convenience, community, or environmental benefits align, but willingness depends on safety, control, and financial fairness.

Key Insights

1. Openness is conditional on trust and safety assurances

- Summary: Drivers are willing to pick up unfamiliar passengers only if the platform provides strong identity verification, in-app communication, and emergency features that reduce perceived risk.
- Impact: Without clear trust signals, many drivers will limit rides to known peers, constraining adoption and network effects. Investing in verifiable university affiliation, photo/ID checks, SOS functionality, and bidirectional ratings will convert cautious drivers into occasional app users, especially for daytime trips. These measures lower social uncertainty, reduce off-platform coordination, and enable safer scaling of the service across more routes and times.
- Variations: Trust requirements tighten during evening hours and for unfamiliar neighborhoods; some users accept weaker verification if there are mutual connections or consistent positive ratings.

2. Community and environmental motivations encourage participation but don't override practicality

- Summary: Drivers value reducing emissions and helping classmates, which motivates offering rides, yet practical concerns (gas, parking, detours) limit how often they'll do so.
- Impact: The app can leverage altruistic drivers by highlighting environmental impact and community benefits, but long-term participation requires addressing practical costs. Optional micro-contributions, easy cost-sharing, and minimized detours (route-aware matching) help sustain behavior. If drivers must repeatedly absorb costs or face significant inconveniences, they will reduce availability or stop participating, eroding the community-driven model.
- Variations: Environmentally motivated users tolerate more unpaid rides; cost-sensitive drivers prefer contributions or fewer, more efficient matches.

3. Control over availability and matching preserves willingness to offer rides

- Summary: Drivers want granular controls (time windows, faculty filters, max detour) so carpooling doesn't feel like an obligation or a job.
- Impact: Preserving driver autonomy prevents burnout and backlash. Features like availability toggles, faculty/route restrictions, pre-ride messaging, and opt-in ride lengths reduce pressure and protect social relationships. If drivers feel tracked, quota-bound, or inundated with requests, they'll opt out or restrict offers, reducing supply and harming reliability for passengers. Respecting driver boundaries sustains a flexible, peer-to-peer culture rather than a commercialized service.
- Variations: More extroverted or service-oriented drivers may accept broader matching; introverted or time-constrained drivers will choose tighter filters and shorter commitments.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "Having a passenger or two actually sounds appealing. For one, it would be a great way to reduce emissions per trip, aligning with my goal to be more environmentally conscious. Plus, sharing expenses like gas could help financially. Also, giving rides to fellow students might foster a sense of community and make the commute more enjoyable with company and conversation."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "I'm pretty selective about it. I mean, I know these people - they're from my classes or I've tutored them before. I'm not just picking up random strangers."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Build strong trust and safety features plus granular driver controls first — these directly unlock broader driver participation.
- Most surprising: Community and environmental motives are strong incentives, but they quickly give way to practical barriers (costs, time, obligation) unless the app actively mitigates them.

Financial Incentives and Contributions

Brief description: Drivers view small, optional contributions as a practical support to cover costs, but their acceptability hinges on being non-mandatory, low-friction, and not transforming rides into paid services that alter peer relationships.

Key Insights

1. Optional micro-contributions increase willingness but must remain voluntary and seamless

- Summary: Small, optional payments motivate drivers by offsetting gas and maintenance costs; however, drivers prefer the option to remain discretionary and processed invisibly through the app.
- Impact: Enabling easy, optional in-app contributions lowers the financial barrier for drivers and supports sustained participation without forcing transactions or awkward face-to-face requests. If contributions are simple (one-tap, suggested amounts), drivers feel compensated without commercialization. This improves supply reliability, especially during high-demand periods like late study sessions, while preserving the social goodwill that currently underpins peer rides.
- Variations: Some drivers (cost-sensitive, frequent drivers) will rely on contributions more; environmentally motivated or altruistic drivers may still offer unpaid rides. Preference for optionality is stronger among those who already help classmates informally.

2. Payments can shift social dynamics — risk of commodification and awkwardness

- Summary: Introducing payments—even optional ones—can change how drivers and passengers perceive the interaction, creating discomfort when peers expect favors rather than transactions.
- Impact: If payments are framed or implemented poorly, drivers worry rides will feel like a service or job rather than mutual help among students. This can erode informal reciprocity, strain friendships, and discourage drivers who prefer helping classmates. To avoid commodification, the app must emphasize cost-sharing and community benefits, limit visible commercialization cues (e.g., avoid receipts that look like invoices), and keep suggested amounts modest.

- Variations: Drivers are more comfortable with contributions from regular riders or tutees than from strangers. Perception of commodification increases when payment flows are visible, large, or handled with high platform fees.

3. Financial viability affects long-term offering frequency and drivers' settings

- Summary: When contributions are rare or insufficient, drivers plan to reduce ride frequency, narrow availability, or require clearer contribution signals to keep offering rides.
- Impact: Drivers balance environmental/community motives with practical costs; persistent unpaid driving leads to fewer offers and tighter filters (fewer detours, stricter time windows). The app should provide transparent cost-estimates, allow drivers to set contribution preferences (e.g., suggested amount, opt-in priority for contributors), and limit platform commission to keep the net benefit meaningful. These measures help maintain a stable driver supply and prevent gradual supply attrition.
- Variations: Some drivers might tolerate occasional unpaid rides for social benefits, while others (high-mileage or inefficient vehicles) will demand contributions or limit offers sooner. Commission sensitivity varies — a small flat fee is more acceptable than high percentage cuts.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "If passengers rarely made a contribution, I might reconsider how often I offer rides."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "I think if payments were really small - like, enough to cover gas but not make it profitable, and totally optional, it could work."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Implement optional, low-friction micro-contributions with transparent suggested amounts and minimal platform fees to support drivers without turning rides into paid work.
- Most surprising: Even environmentally motivated drivers will reduce participation if contributions are consistently absent — goodwill alone doesn't sustain long-term supply.

Safety Concerns and Features

Brief description: Drivers' willingness to offer rides hinges on clear safety guarantees — identity verification, real-time tracking and communication, and emergency tools — plus controls that let drivers limit exposure (time, route, passenger type).

Key Insights

1. Strong identity verification and accountability are non-negotiable

- Summary: Drivers expect verified IDs tied to university affiliation, profile photos that match, and evidence of prior behavior (ratings/history) before accepting unfamiliar passengers.
- Impact: Without robust verification, many drivers will restrict rides to known peers, severely limiting network growth and midday/evening coverage. Tying accounts to university emails/IDs, enforcing photo checks, and surfacing mutual connections or rating histories reduces perceived anonymity and increases accountability. This supports safer scaling, encourages drivers to accept occasional strangers, and lowers reliance on informal, off-platform coordination that lacks audit trails.
- Variations: Some drivers will accept lighter signals (consistent positive ratings or mutual connections) instead of formal institutional checks; others (especially those more risk-averse or driving late at night) insist on strict validation.

2. Real-time tracking, in-ride visibility, and emergency tools materially increase comfort

- Summary: Features like live route sharing, SOS/emergency buttons, and automatic trip logging are essential to address safety concerns during drives.
- Impact: Real-time location sharing with trusted contacts and an in-app SOS create concrete safety nets that make drivers comfortable offering rides at more times and on longer routes. These features generate an audit trail for incidents and provide quick escalation paths, which reduces drivers' perceived personal risk and the emotional burden of helping strangers. Well-integrated safety flows also reassure drivers' families, an important social factor affecting participation decisions.

- Variations: Some users prefer automatic sharing only for the duration of a ride; others are comfortable with continuous app tracking during availability windows. The preferred visibility level often depends on personal privacy concerns and previous experience with ride-sharing tools.

3. Pre-ride communication, clear pickup/drop confirmations, and driver controls reduce situational risk

- Summary: In-app messaging, confirmed pickup/drop points, and granular driver preferences (time windows, max detour, faculty filters) prevent awkward or unsafe situations and preserve driver autonomy.
- Impact: Clear coordination eliminates common stressors—wrong meeting points, unexpected detours, last-minute route changes—that can escalate into unsafe or uncomfortable interactions. Giving drivers control to set boundaries (e.g., no late-night pickups, limit to same-faculty riders, accept only passengers with positive ratings) reduces pressure and the chance of being solicited for risky requests. These controls also protect social ties by preventing scenarios where drivers feel obligated or exploited.
- Variations: Extroverted or community-oriented drivers may opt for broader matching and fewer restrictions; risk-sensitive or time-constrained drivers will choose conservative settings and daytime-only availability.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "For me, 'verified IDs' would mean having a few key pieces of information validated through the app."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "If we're talking about an actual app... the first thing I'd need is really solid identity verification. Like, not just a profile picture that could be anyone, but something that connects to their university ID or student email."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Prioritize multi-layered verification, real-time trip visibility, and an easy-to-access emergency flow combined with granular driver controls to convert cautious drivers into regular users.
- Most surprising: Simple coordination features (confirmed pickup/drop and pre-ride messaging) are as critical to perceived safety as major technical safeguards — they prevent many low-risk-but-high-friction situations that currently deter drivers.

Impact on Social Dynamics

Brief description: Carpooling via an app can strengthen campus ties and community norms but also risks commodifying informal favors, changing peer expectations, and introducing pressure that alters existing student relationships.

Key Insights

1. Risk of commodification — payments and ratings can shift favors into transactions

- Summary: Introducing payments or visible ratings can change how rides are perceived, turning informal help among classmates into a service exchange subject to evaluation.
- Impact: When rides acquire monetary or performance signals, students may recalibrate expectations—reciprocity can weaken and interactions may feel more transactional. This threatens the informal support networks (tutoring, last-minute rides) that currently rely on goodwill. If the platform emphasizes invoices, high fees, or public ratings, drivers who prize community ties may withdraw, or relationships may become awkward as peers negotiate contributions and service standards rather than mutual aid.
- Variations: Commodification concerns intensify when payments are prominent or commission rates are high; they lessen when contributions are optional, discreet, and small. Trust-built relationships (regular tutees/classmates) tolerate modest monetization more than ad-hoc stranger matches.

2. App mediation can erode spontaneous, authentic interactions

- Summary: Many drivers value the personal, low-pressure conversations during rides; app-mediated, transactional flows may reduce those organic exchanges.
- Impact: Rides often function as informal social spaces where students bond, share academic help, and support each other emotionally. If the app routinizes pickups, emphasizes matching efficiency, or enforces evaluation norms, these casual moments may disappear. The loss of authentic interactions can weaken peer networks, reduce informal mentorship opportunities, and make the travel experience less rewarding, which may reduce drivers' intrinsic motivation to continue offering rides.

- Variations: Extroverted drivers or those seeking networking may welcome more matches and new contacts; introverted drivers prefer private, known-people rides and will use filters to avoid high-social-cost matches.

3. Perceived obligation and platform pressure threaten driver autonomy

- Summary: Students fear an app could create expectations to accept rides, implement quotas, or monitor availability, which would turn voluntary help into a perceived duty.
- Impact: When drivers feel obligated—by visibility of requests, implied community norms, or platform metrics—they may experience stress and reduce participation to protect personal time. Autonomy-preserving features (availability toggles, selective visibility, no-penalty decline policies) are crucial to prevent burnout. Without these, the platform risks alienating regular informal drivers and shrinking the supply of willing participants, undermining reliability for passengers.
- Variations: Pressure sensitivity varies by personality and current role (e.g., tutors who already balance obligations are more sensitive). Time-of-day expectations (late-night availability) amplify perceived obligation concerns.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "If it started becoming financially burdensome, I'd probably limit the number of rides I offer each week."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "Right now, when I give someone a ride, it feels personal."

Key Takeaways

- Preserve the informal, community-first feel: make payments optional, discreet, and modest; avoid heavy-handed rating displays.
- Protect driver autonomy with clear controls (availability, filters, no-penalty declines) to prevent platform-induced social pressure.

Potential App Features

Brief description: Recommended feature set focused on converting cautious student drivers into regular contributors by addressing safety, ease-of-use, and driver autonomy while preserving campus community norms.

Key Insights

1. Safety-first feature bundle (verification, SOS, tracking, ratings)

- Summary: Combine verified university affiliation, photo/ID checks, bidirectional ratings, live trip sharing, and an easy SOS/emergency flow as a foundational trust layer.
- Impact: A multi-layered safety approach reduces perceived anonymity and personal risk, enabling drivers to accept unfamiliar passengers—especially during daytime and early evening. Verification tied to university credentials plus visible rating histories creates accountability; live tracking and SOS provide immediate reassurance to drivers and their contacts. Together these features increase adoption by lowering psychological barriers and creating an evidentiary trail for incidents, which also reassures drivers' families and supports safer scaling.
- Variations: Some drivers will accept softer signals (consistent positive ratings, mutual connections) instead of strict institutional checks; others (night drivers) demand full verification and prefer additional safeguards like route vetting or emergency contacts pre-registered.

2. Flexible, optional micro-payments with transparent, low-fee flows

- Summary: Offer one-tap suggested contributions, transparent cost breakdowns, driver-set suggested amounts, and a minimal platform commission to offset fuel without commodifying rides.
- Impact: Easy, optional payments reduce friction in cost-sharing and help drivers sustain offering rides financially. When contributions are discreet and modest they support continued participation without turning rides into a commercial service. Transparent receipts and low commissions preserve trust; driver-configurable suggested amounts and priority matching for contributors let drivers protect time and recoup costs. Poorly designed payment flows (high fees, mandatory charges) would push drivers away and harm social dynamics.

- Variations: Some drivers prefer no payments and may disable the feature; others rely on contributions frequently. Acceptance of payments is higher among drivers with higher costs (inefficient cars, long detours) and lower when riders are known peers.

3. Granular driver controls and friction-reducing UX

- Summary: Enable availability toggles, faculty/route filters, max detour/time settings, pre-ride chat, confirmed pickup/drop points, and route optimization to minimize coordination friction and perceived obligation.
- Impact: Empowering drivers with fine-grained controls preserves autonomy and prevents burnout. Availability toggles and no-penalty decline policies reduce social pressure; faculty or mutual-connection filters increase perceived safety. Pre-ride messaging and confirmed meeting points eliminate common misunderstandings that escalate into uncomfortable or unsafe interactions. Route optimization and clear estimated detour times keep trips efficient, supporting drivers' willingness to accept occasional passengers without sacrificing convenience.
- Variations: Extroverted or community-focused drivers may keep open availability and fewer filters, while introverted or time-constrained drivers will prefer strict limits and daytime-only matching. Some drivers want visibility into passenger history before accepting; others prefer minimal pre-ride contact.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "Driving in Mérida can be quite the experience due to the traffic, especially in busy areas near the university."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "I always let someone know where I'm going - usually just a quick text to my roommate or something."

Key Takeaways

- Prioritize a combined stack: robust verification + live-trip safety tools + optional, low-friction payments + granular driver controls — this mix unlocks participation while protecting community norms.
- Most surprising: Simple coordination features (confirmed pickup/drop and in-app messaging) can be as impactful for driver comfort as heavyweight technical safeguards.

Surprising Insight

Brief description: Beyond expected needs like verification and payments, the interviews revealed counterintuitive drivers of participation — small coordination fixes and preservation of autonomy often matter more than heavyweight safety or financial incentives.

Key Insights

1. Low-friction coordination outweighs some high-tech safety features

- Summary: Simple UX elements (clear pickup/drop confirmations, pre-ride messaging, explicit meeting points, and route estimates) reduce hesitation more than additional verification layers in many cases.
- Impact: Drivers report that many refusals stem from everyday friction—misunderstood pickup locations, unexpected detours, or awkward coordination—rather than purely from identity fears. Addressing these small pain points through lightweight features will increase completed rides and driver confidence quickly and at low cost. Prioritizing coordination UX shortens decision time, reduces time-wasting interactions, and scales supply more reliably than investing first in complex background-check systems.
- Variations: This matters most for daytime or familiar-route rides where trust is moderate; for late-night or stranger pickups, heavyweight safety features regain primacy.

2. Relational signals (faculty ties, mutual connections) can substitute for formal verification

- Summary: Drivers place strong weight on shared context—being from the same faculty, known classmates, or tutoring relationships—as trust signals that sometimes replace the need for institutional checks.
- Impact: Social provenance (mutual courses, existing study groups, tutor-tutee ties) lowers perceived risk and preserves the community feeling that motivates offering rides. An app that surfaces mutual connections, class overlap, or shared groups can unlock more matches without forcing formal identity workflows. This approach supports organic growth by leveraging campus social graphs while reducing friction for users who already rely on interpersonal cues rather than formal credentials.

- Variations: For users who drive at night or have higher safety concerns, relational signals are insufficient and must be complemented by strict verification and emergency tools.

3. Autonomy concerns trump small financial gains

- Summary: Drivers are sensitive to control—being tracked, pressured to accept requests, or subject to quotas—and these autonomy losses discourage participation even when payments are available.
- Impact: Optional micro-payments help, but many drivers would stop offering rides if the platform erodes their ability to choose (e.g., mandatory availability windows, penalties for declining, background tracking). Protecting voluntary participation through availability toggles, no-penalty declines, and temporary location sharing keeps drivers engaged; failing to do so risks losing supply regardless of financial incentives. The platform should therefore prioritize driver agency as a core design principle to sustain long-term engagement.
- Variations: Some users are less sensitive to autonomy loss (extroverted or community-focused drivers) and may accept broader obligations in exchange for consistent contributors or small payments.

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "I don't do it often because of the hassle of parking and my efforts to be more environmentally conscious."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "What struck me was how relieved she looked when we got to her neighborhood."

Key Takeaways

- Most important: Fixing everyday coordination frictions (meeting points, pre-ride chat, route clarity) unlocks driver participation faster and cheaper than many heavyweight features.
- Most surprising: Protecting driver autonomy (no quotas, selective visibility, temporary tracking) is often more critical than offering small payments — drivers will forgo money to avoid losing control.

Suggested Follow-Up Question

Brief description: A focused question to probe students' exact trade-offs between safety, payment, and autonomy—designed to reveal thresholds that determine whether they will offer rides through the app and under what conditions.

Key Insights

1. Need to quantify acceptable contribution amounts and frequency

- Summary: Participants say optional micro-payments motivate them, but they haven't specified exact amounts or how often contributions must occur to sustain offering rides.
- Impact: Without numeric thresholds, designers can't set suggested amounts, priority-matching rules, or reasonable commission caps. Asking for specific money ranges (e.g., per trip, per km, monthly expectations) and acceptable frequency (e.g., how many unpaid rides before reducing availability) reveals the economic boundary between voluntary help and unsustainable burden. These figures directly influence pricing UX, suggested contribution defaults, and whether drivers should be given priority matching based on contribution willingness.
- Variations: Amounts will vary by vehicle fuel efficiency, typical detour length, and personal financial situation; some drivers accept occasional unpaid rides for community value, while others need regular compensation to continue.

2. Clarify which verification signals are sufficient vs. excessive

- Summary: Drivers list multiple trust signals (university ID, student email, mutual connections, ratings) but differ on which combination makes them comfortable.
- Impact: Understanding which single or combined verification elements are minimally sufficient (e.g., student email + profile photo vs. formal institutional verification or background checks) lets the app balance onboarding friction and perceived safety. This determines whether the platform prioritizes lightweight social-graph signals or invests in stronger identity integrations with the university. The answer shapes adoption speed, the cost of verification, and the app's positioning as a low-friction campus tool versus a formally vetted service.
- Variations: Daytime/familiar-route rides tolerate lighter signals (mutual classes, positive ratings); late-night or stranger pickups typically require stronger institutional verification or additional safeguards.

3. Map autonomy boundaries: what controls drivers require to avoid feeling obligated

- Summary: Drivers repeatedly express autonomy concerns (no quotas, temporary location sharing, availability toggles) but have not specified exact limits or acceptable defaults.
- Impact: Precise knowledge of acceptable defaults and hard boundaries (e.g., maximum daily requests visible, opt-out rates, whether permanent background location access is ever acceptable) will shape core product rules and default settings. If defaults are perceived as coercive, many drivers will disable the app or restrict participation. Clear answers enable designers to craft safe defaults that protect drivers while still enabling discoverability—for example, setting “invisible unless active” location sharing and firm no-penalty decline policies.
- Variations: Sensitivity varies by personality (extroverts vs introverts), role (tutors vs casual drivers), and time of day; some drivers tolerate more visibility for consistent contributors, others insist on minimal persistent tracking.

Suggested Follow-Up Question (primary + probes)

Primary question: - "What exact combination of verification, payment, and control features (please rank and quantify) would make you feel comfortable offering X rides per week through an app?"

Probing sub-questions: - "What is a reasonable suggested contribution per trip (range in MXN) that would make you keep offering rides? How many unpaid rides per week would you tolerate before reducing availability?" - "Which verification signals alone would be enough for you to accept a stranger in your car? (student email, university ID upload, mutual class overlap, 3+ positive driver ratings, background check, etc.)" - "Which app behaviors feel like a loss of autonomy (e.g., mandatory availability, always-on location)? For each, would a temporary or opt-in variant be acceptable?"

Relevant Quotes

Ximena Kú Paredes: "The option for passengers to make an optional payment or contribution would definitely be a motivating factor for me."

Efraín Cocom Chan: "I'm pretty selective about it. I mean, I know these people - they're from my classes or I've tutored them before. I'm not just picking up random strangers."

Key Takeaways

- Actionable: Ask participants to give numeric ranges and rank verification/control options—these concrete thresholds directly inform default settings, suggested contributions, and verification investment.
- Insightful: The critical trade-offs are measurable; once you know the money ranges, minimum verification combos, and exact autonomy limits, you can design defaults that maximize participation without eroding community norms.

SyntheticUsers

Interviews

SyntheticUsers

Interview #1

Efraín Cocom Chan

Personal Information

Age	24
Location	Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico
Profession	Mathematics student (Facultad de Matemáticas, UADY); part-time tutoring

Dynamic Parameters

Transportation Habits	Own small car used for commute between university and neighborhood; offers rides occasionally
Social Connectivity	Smaller circle — tutors peers, active on Telegram and Facebook, moderate campus involvement
Risk Perception	Higher sensitivity to safety for late-night rides; prefers known passengers and in-app verification
Technology Usage	Very High — tech-savvy, uses apps for navigation, payments, and scheduling; values in-app ID verification and rating systems
Environmental Awareness	Moderate — supports carpooling to reduce trips but less focused on environmental issues than convenience

Personality Traits

Openness To Experience	3
Conscientiousness	5
Extraversion	2
Agreeableness	5
Neuroticism	2

Interview Transcript

Interviewer:

How often, if at all, do you currently use your car to give rides to others between the university and your home?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

Pretty regularly, actually. I'd say maybe three or four times a week? It's not like I'm running a taxi service or anything, but since I have my car and live in a neighborhood where a lot of other math students are, it just... happens naturally.

Most of the time it's people I tutor or study with. Like, if we're working late on problem sets and someone needs to get home, I'll offer. Or if I'm heading to campus and I see someone I know waiting at the bus stop, I'll pull over.

The thing is, I'm pretty selective about it. I mean, I know these people - they're from my classes or I've tutored them before. I'm not just picking up random strangers. That would make me uncomfortable, especially with some of the late hours we keep during exam periods. But yeah, having the car means I end up being the guy people ask for rides, which is fine most of the time.

Interviewer:

Can you tell me about the most recent time you gave someone a ride, and how that experience was for you?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

shifts slightly

Oh, that was just this past Thursday, actually. I was leaving campus around 8 PM after a study session in the library, and I ran into Sofía - she's in my Abstract Algebra class and I've tutored her a few times in Calculus. She was looking pretty stressed, checking her phone constantly.

Turns out the bus she usually takes was running really late, and she had this whole situation where she needed to get home to help her mom with something. I could see she was genuinely worried about it, not just being dramatic, you know? So I offered her a ride.

The drive was... well, it was fine, but also a bit awkward at first. She kept thanking me over and over, which made me feel weird because it's not like I was doing this huge favor. I mean, we were going in the same general direction anyway. But then she started asking me about this problem from our homework that she'd been stuck on, and that felt more natural - talking about math always does.

What struck me was how relieved she looked when we got to her neighborhood. Like, genuinely relieved. Made me realize that having the car gives me this flexibility that not everyone has, especially when public transport gets unreliable. I guess I take it for granted sometimes. The whole thing took maybe fifteen minutes longer than my usual route home, but seeing how much stress it saved her... I don't know, it felt worth it.

Interviewer:

What are some of the safety factors you consider when deciding whether to give someone a ride?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

pauses for a moment

Honestly, safety is probably the biggest thing I think about, especially after dark. I mean, I'm not paranoid, but I've had to learn to be more careful than I used to be.

The main thing is - do I actually know this person? Not just "oh, I've seen them around campus," but like, have I had actual conversations with them, been in study groups together, that kind of thing. There's a big difference between someone I've tutored for weeks and someone who's just in my Differential Equations class but I've never really talked to.

Time of day is huge too. During the day, I'm more flexible about it. But once it gets dark, especially after 9 PM, I'm way more selective. I've had people ask me for rides to parts of the city I don't know well, and at night... no, I'm not doing that. I stick to routes I know, neighborhoods I'm familiar with.

And this might sound weird, but I pay attention to how they ask. If someone's being pushy about it, or if they seem agitated or off somehow, that's a red flag for me. The people I regularly give rides to, they ask politely and they're understanding if I can't do it.

runs hand through hair

The other thing is, I always let someone know where I'm going - usually just a quick text to my roommate or something. Not because I think something bad will happen, but just... it feels smarter, you know? My mom didn't raise an idiot. She'd probably be worried sick if she knew how often I give people rides, actually.

Interviewer:

What features or assurances in a carpooling app would encourage you to offer rides to others more frequently?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

leans back a bit

Okay, so if we're talking about an actual app... the first thing I'd need is really solid identity verification. Like, not just a profile picture that could be anyone, but something that connects to their university ID or student email. I need to know this person is actually a UADY student, not just someone who figured out how to game the system.

Rating systems would be essential too - but both ways, you know? I want to see what other drivers have said about this person, but I also want passengers to be able to rate me. That creates accountability on both sides. If someone has a pattern of being late, or making drivers uncomfortable, or whatever, I want to know that upfront.

Real-time location sharing during the ride would make me feel a lot more secure. Like, the app tracks the route and maybe sends it to an emergency contact automatically. That way if something goes weird, there's a digital trail.

gestures with hands

And honestly? Some kind of in-app messaging before confirming the ride. I want to be able to chat briefly with the person, get a sense of who they are, confirm pickup details. Sometimes you can tell a lot about someone just from how they communicate in text, you know?

Payment through the app would be good too - removes that awkward "do I ask for gas money" conversation. Even if it's just small amounts, having it handled automatically makes the whole thing more professional.

Oh, and maybe some way to set preferences - like "students from math faculty only" or "rides ending before 10 PM." Give drivers control over who they're matched with based on their comfort level. Because honestly, having more control over the situation would definitely make me more willing to offer rides to people I don't know personally.

Interviewer:

What might make you hesitant about using a carpooling app like this, if at all?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

fidgets with phone

Um, honestly? A few things worry me about putting this whole thing through an app.

First off, it would probably make me feel like I have to give rides more often, you know? Right now, if I'm tired or just want to drive home alone listening to music, I can do that without anyone knowing. But with an app, there's this expectation that if I'm driving and someone needs a ride on my route, I should offer. That pressure would probably stress me out.

The money thing is weird too. Like, right now when I give Sofía or whoever a ride, it's just... helping out a classmate. But once there's an app calculating payments and taking percentages, it starts feeling like work. And I already tutor part-time - I don't really want my car rides to become another side hustle, even a small one.

pauses

And then there's the whole thing about strangers rating me. I mean, what if someone has a bad day and gives me a low rating because I didn't want to make small talk during the ride? Or because my car's not the cleanest? I'm pretty introverted, so the idea of being constantly evaluated by people I barely know... that makes me uncomfortable.

Also, what happens if the app gets popular and suddenly I have random people messaging me for rides all the time? I like being able to help people I know, but I don't want to become the neighborhood Uber driver. I've seen what happens to people who are too helpful - they end up getting taken advantage of.

And honestly? Part of me worries about the safety verification not being as good as it claims to be. Apps get hacked, people fake profiles... at least when I'm giving rides to people I know from class, I can trust my own judgment about them.

Interviewer:

What impact, if any, do you think using a carpooling app might have on your interactions with other students?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

looks down for a moment, then back up

Hmm, that's actually something I hadn't really thought about deeply, but... I think it could change things in ways I'm not sure I'd like?

Right now, when I give someone a ride, it feels personal. Like, Sofía and I have this relationship where I've tutored her, we've worked on problem sets together, and sometimes I help her get home. It's part of our friendship, I guess. There's this trust there that we've built up over time.

But with an app... I don't know, it might make everything feel more transactional? Like, instead of "hey, can you help me out," it becomes this formal request through a platform. And then there's money involved, ratings, all that stuff. It might actually make my relationships with classmates more awkward, not easier.

shifts in seat

Plus, I worry about creating expectations I can't meet. Right now, if someone I tutor needs a ride and I can't do it, they understand - I'm just another student, not a service. But if I'm on a carpooling app, and they see I'm driving home, they might feel like I'm choosing not to help them specifically. That could hurt feelings or make tutoring sessions weird.

And honestly? Some of my best conversations happen during these rides. Like, people open up when they're in your car - they'll talk about struggles with classes, family stuff, whatever. If it becomes this rated, app-mediated thing, I think that genuine connection might disappear. People might feel like they need to perform or be polite instead of just... being real.

I mean, I could see it helping me meet new people from other faculties, which might be cool. But I'd hate to lose the authentic relationships I already have over making everything more "efficient," you know?

Interviewer:

How do you feel about receiving optional payments or contributions from passengers, if any?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

scratches head

Oh man, that's... it's complicated, actually. Like, I have really mixed feelings about it.

On one hand, gas isn't free, right? And sometimes when I'm giving people rides regularly - like during finals when everyone's staying late at the library - it does add up. My car's not exactly fuel-efficient, and driving around the city more than I normally would definitely costs me.

But then there's this weird thing where... I don't know, asking for money from classmates feels uncomfortable? Like, when I offered Sofía that ride last week, the thought of being like "hey, can you give me 20 pesos for gas" just felt wrong. She's someone I tutor, we study together - it would change the whole dynamic.

fidgets with keys

I guess if it was optional and handled through the app, that might be less awkward. Like, people could contribute if they want to without this whole conversation about it. Some people might appreciate being able to help with gas costs, especially if they're getting regular rides.

But honestly? Part of me worries it would attract the wrong kind of attention, you know? Like, people might start seeing me as someone who's trying to make money off giving rides rather than just... helping out. And then there's this expectation that if someone pays, I need to provide better service or whatever.

shrugs

I think if payments were really small - like, enough to cover gas but not make it profitable - and totally optional, it could work. But the moment it starts feeling like I'm running a business instead of just being a helpful classmate, I'd probably stop using it. I already make money tutoring; I don't need my car to become another job, even accidentally.

Interviewer:

What would you find most important for a carpooling app to facilitate smooth and stress-free experiences with passengers?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

leans forward slightly

The most important thing? Honestly, it would have to be really clear communication before the ride even happens.

Like, I need to know exactly where we're meeting, what time, where we're going - all of that sorted out beforehand through the app. Because right now, when I give rides to people I know, there's still this awkward dance of "where should I pick you up" and "oh, I thought you meant the other entrance" and then someone's standing in the wrong place for ten minutes.

gestures while talking

And I'd need some way to set expectations upfront. Like, can I say in my profile that I prefer not to make small talk during rides? Or that I listen to instrumental music while driving? Because some people want to chat the whole time, and some days I'm just... not up for that, you know? Nothing personal, I just need that quiet time.

A reliable messaging system within the app would be huge too. Sometimes plans change - maybe I'm running late because my professor held us over, or traffic is worse than expected. Being able to quickly update someone without having to get their phone number feels important.

pauses

Oh, and automatic route optimization. I don't want to spend fifteen minutes trying to figure out the best way to get to someone's neighborhood, especially somewhere I've never been. If the app can just tell me the most efficient route that gets everyone where they need to go, that removes a lot of stress.

And maybe... some kind of "ride preferences" matching? Like, if I mark that I'm okay with rides up to 30 minutes extra, only match me with people whose destinations fit that. Or if someone prefers drivers who are okay with them making phone calls during the ride, they get matched with people who don't mind that.

Basically, anything that removes those awkward negotiations and misunderstandings that make the whole experience stressful for everyone involved.

Interviewer:

What might discourage you from using a carpooling app, if anything?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

runs hand through hair

Well, honestly, a bunch of things could put me off pretty quickly.

The biggest one would probably be if it became too demanding, you know? Like, if I open the app and suddenly there's five people requesting rides and I feel guilty saying no to all of them. Right now I can choose when to help and when I just want to drive home alone, but an app might make that harder.

Also, if the verification system turns out to be weak. I mean, they can promise all they want about student ID verification, but what if someone figures out how to fake it? Or what if the university doesn't actually cooperate with the app? I'd be back to not really knowing who I'm picking up, which defeats the whole purpose for me.

shifts uncomfortably

And honestly? If it gets too popular with people outside our faculty. I know that sounds kind of... exclusive or whatever, but there's something about giving rides to other math students that feels safer. We have classes together, professors know us, there's accountability. If it becomes this big university-wide thing, I might end up with people from completely different social circles who I have no way to verify.

Technical problems would kill it for me too. Like, if the app crashes when I'm trying to coordinate a pickup, or if the payment system is buggy, or if it drains my phone battery... I don't have patience for that kind of stuff when I'm just trying to get home after a long day.

pauses

Oh, and if other drivers start treating it like a real business - you know, getting competitive about routes or ratings, or if there's drama in the app community. I've seen how toxic some online groups can get, and I really don't want that energy around something as simple as sharing rides. I'd probably just go back to only giving rides to people I already know personally.

Interviewer:

What would be a dealbreaker for you when considering to use a carpooling app?

Efraín Cocom Chan:

leans back and crosses arms

A dealbreaker? Definitely if the app required me to accept a certain number of rides or maintain some kind of activity level to stay on the platform. Like, if there was pressure to be available regularly or penalties for declining too many requests.

I'm not running a transportation business - I'm a student who sometimes has extra space in my car. If the app starts treating me like an employee with quotas or performance metrics, I'm out immediately.

shakes head

Oh, and if they wanted access to my location all the time, even when I'm not offering rides. Some apps do that tracking thing where they know where you are 24/7, and that's just... no. I'll turn on location sharing when I'm actively giving someone a ride, but I don't need some company knowing every time I go to the corner store or visit my girlfriend.

The other absolute dealbreaker would be if they took too big a cut of any payments. Like, if passengers are contributing money for gas and the app is taking 30% or something ridiculous like that... at that point they're just profiting off students trying to help each other out. That would feel really wrong to me.

voice gets more serious

And honestly? If I ever felt like the app was compromising my safety because they weren't doing proper verification, or if there was some incident where someone got hurt because the safety features didn't work... I'd delete it immediately.

My mom already worries about me driving around the city at night. If I had to tell her that someone got in my car through an app and something bad happened, I don't think I could live with that. My peace of mind isn't worth the convenience.

Interview #2

Ximena Kú Paredes

Personal Information

Age	22
Location	Mérida, Yucatán, Mexico
Profession	Mathematics student (Facultad de Matemáticas, UADY); campus research assistant

Dynamic Parameters

Transportation Habits	Mostly uses public bus and motorcycle; occasionally drives parent's car
Social Connectivity	Broad campus network — active in student government, math society, and Instagram study groups
Risk Perception	Balances convenience with safety; would offer rides if app provides verified IDs, SOS feature, and clear pickup/drop confirmations
Technology Usage	Very High — prefers mobile-first solutions, uses map/apps, digital payments, and values in-app communication and ratings
Environmental Awareness	High — motivated by reducing emissions and supports sharing rides when it lowers traffic and carbon footprint

Personality Traits

Openness To Experience	5
Conscientiousness	4
Extraversion	4
Agreeableness	4
Neuroticism	3

Interview Transcript

Interviewer:

Thinking about your trips between the university and a point near your home, when was the most recent time you drove a car, if at all, and what was that experience like?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

The last time I drove a car was about a week ago. I borrowed my parents' car because I had to carry some heavy textbooks and supplies back home, and it was just more convenient than taking the bus or my motorcycle.

Driving in Mérida can be quite the experience due to the traffic, especially in busy areas near the university. It was a bit stressful at first because I'm not super used to driving cars in such congestion, but having the freedom to control the air conditioning and music was a nice change from my usual bus rides. I was a bit on edge keeping an eye out for the many pedestrians and cyclists, but overall, it felt pretty efficient. That said, I don't do it often because of the hassle of parking and my efforts to be more environmentally conscious.

Interviewer:

Considering your environmental consciousness and the challenges you mentioned with parking and traffic when driving, what comes to mind about the idea of having a passenger or two with you on those trips between the university and home, if you were driving?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

Having a passenger or two actually sounds appealing. For one, it would be a great way to reduce emissions per trip, aligning with my goal to be more environmentally conscious. Plus, sharing expenses like gas could help financially. Also, giving rides to fellow students might foster a sense of community and make the commute more enjoyable with company and conversation.

Of course, there are some concerns, like making sure everyone is safe and comfortable with the arrangement. I'd want to ensure that the pickup and drop-off details are clear and that everyone feels secure, especially considering traffic and hectic schedules. Overall, if there were an organized platform with verified IDs and safety features, I'd be all for it.

Interviewer:

Thinking about offering rides through an app, what role, if any, would the option for passengers to make an optional payment or contribution play in your decision to offer a ride?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

The option for passengers to make an optional payment or contribution would definitely be a motivating factor for me. It would help cover gas and maintenance costs, making driving a bit more sustainable financially. While I wouldn't expect it every time, it's nice to have the option there, showing appreciation for the ride and recognizing the effort involved.

Besides the financial aspect, having this option could also encourage more people to participate, knowing that they can contribute if they find it valuable. It adds a sense of fairness and shared responsibility, which aligns with the collaborative spirit I'd want in a ride-sharing experience.

Interviewer:

What specific safety factors or features, if any, would you consider absolutely essential for you to feel comfortable offering a ride to someone you don't know through an app?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

Several safety features would be essential for me to feel comfortable offering a ride. First, verified IDs for everyone involved would be crucial. Knowing that there's a verification process builds trust and accountability. An SOS feature is also important for handling emergencies swiftly and discreetly.

Clear pickup and drop-off confirmations would help avoid confusion and ensure that both parties are on the same page. In-app communication is another must-have, so I can easily coordinate details and stay informed about any changes or concerns.

Additionally, I'd appreciate a rating or review system. It provides insight into potential passengers' experiences and offers a way to address any issues that arise. These features together would make the idea of offering rides through an app a lot more secure and appealing.

Interviewer:

When you think about "verified IDs," what specific information about a passenger would make you feel their identity is adequately verified for you to comfortably offer a ride?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

For me, "verified IDs" would mean having a few key pieces of information validated through the app. I'd want to see a full name and a photo that matches their profile, as well as confirmation of their phone number or email. It'd be reassuring to know there's some sort of background check or identity verification process by the platform itself.

It might also help if the app includes a bit of feedback or history from other drivers who have interacted with this passenger, just to get some insights into their reliability and behavior. This info would make me feel more confident about the arrangement.

Interviewer:

Regarding feedback or history from other drivers, what specific types of past passenger behavior or interactions, if any, would you look for to decide if you'd feel comfortable offering a ride?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

I'd be looking for feedback that highlights key aspects of past interactions. Things like punctuality and reliability are important—knowing if they consistently show up on time and commit to the arrangements made.

Respectful communication is another big one. I'd want to see if previous drivers mentioned positive, polite, or clear interactions. Safety goes both ways, so remarks on whether they followed guidelines or behaved appropriately would also be crucial.

Additionally, feedback on mutual respect for personal space and boundaries during the ride would make a big difference. Knowing that other drivers felt comfortable with a passenger would definitely influence my decision to offer a ride.

Interviewer:

What specific feedback or past behavior would make you decide not to offer a ride to a particular passenger?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

If I saw feedback indicating that a passenger was consistently late or canceled frequently, that would be a red flag. Unreliable communication, like not responding to messages or being unclear about arrangements, would also make me hesitant.

Negative remarks about disrespectful behavior, such as not respecting personal space or making others uncomfortable during the ride, would definitely stop me from offering a ride. Any mention of disregarding safety guidelines or causing disturbances would be a no-go as well. These factors would make me feel uneasy about the potential interaction.

Interviewer:

You mentioned that an optional payment would be a motivating factor, but also that you wouldn't expect it every time. What would happen if passengers rarely made a contribution, if anything?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

If passengers rarely made a contribution, I might reconsider how often I offer rides. While the main motivation is about reducing emissions and building a sense of community, the financial aspect can't be ignored entirely. Covering costs like gas is important, and without contributions, it could become less sustainable for me to keep offering rides.

However, I'd also weigh this against the positive experiences and connections made during the rides. If those aspects remained fulfilling, I might continue but on a more limited basis. I'd probably look for ways to encourage contributions or perhaps have open conversations with regular riders about sharing expenses. But overall, if it became financially burdensome, it would definitely impact my decision to continue offering rides.

Interviewer:

If offering rides became financially burdensome, what specific changes, if any, would you make to how you offer rides?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

If it started becoming financially burdensome, I'd probably limit the number of rides I offer each week. I might focus on sharing rides only during peak times when there's more demand, balancing out the costs better.

I could set clear expectations with regular passengers about contributions, gently reminding them of the option to contribute. If the app allows for it, I might also adjust my settings to prioritize passengers who've indicated willingness to make a contribution.

Ultimately, I'd look for a balance where offering rides remains feasible and aligns with my goal of reducing emissions, without stretching my budget too thin.

Interviewer:

Do you notice any tension between your environmental awareness goals and the need for financial contributions when considering offering rides, if any?

Ximena Kú Paredes:

Yeah, there's definitely some tension between wanting to be environmentally conscious and needing financial contributions for sustainability. On one hand, I'm motivated to reduce emissions and traffic by sharing rides, which feels really rewarding. But on the other hand, covering costs like gas and maintenance is a real concern.

It feels like a balancing act. Ideally, I'd love to do my part for the environment without worrying about the financial side, but the reality is both are important. Finding ways to manage contributions smoothly, maybe through app settings or open communication, helps ease that tension a bit. Ultimately, I want to do good for the planet while also taking care of practical needs.

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